

Antisemitism and the Early Palestinian Nationalist Movement in the Mandate Period

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Introduction

Hamas's attack on October 7 and Israel's subsequent retaliation, which has left more than 70,000 Gazans dead, renewed conversations about the national and religious character of the Arab-Israeli conflict. Arab and Jewish identities are intertwined in discourse and political action in Israel-Palestine, and politicians, the media, and academics alike frequently blame religious animosity for the absence of peace today. Discussing antisemitism is particularly important in today's context with the existence of Islamist terror and militia organizations such as Hamas and Hezbollah that target Jews in Israel and around the world.

Following the attacks carried out by Hamas, many conclude that Palestinian nationalism should be characterized by a violent hatred of Jews. Many associate antisemitism and anti-Zionism for this reason. In an article that he titles "Antisemitism, A Guide for the Perplexed," Bret Stephens makes this association, explicitly concluding that Judaism and Zionism are inextricably linked. He writes, "Remember that antisemitism can also take the form of political hatred, and Zionism — that is, support for the existence of a Jewish state, as opposed to any of its policies — is today the principal expression of Jewish politics. But even anti-Zionism increasingly expresses itself as a conspiracy theory (2023).

Charges of antisemitism evidently shape public opinion and the ways in which we discuss the conflict, where certain discussions and arguments are dismissed for being antisemitic. Israel and its staunchest supporters claim they have never had a "partner for peace" because they believe Palestinians support militant groups like Hamas out of deep-seated anti-Jewish views that stem from Arab culture. For instance, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu claims that a Palestinian state "will be another terror haven" that teaches antisemitic beliefs and encourages violence

against Jews (Nereim, 2024). It is worth investigating the development of Palestinian nationalism and the extent to which antisemitism was present critically to determine how we should characterize the movement, past and present.

Unlike the narrative which writers like Stephens and political leaders like Netanyahu push about Palestinian nationalists' present and historic hatred of Jews, there is no evidence to suggest that there was a universal anti-Jewish sentiment within the Muslim Arab population in the early 1900s. Muslim Arabs describe a positive relationship with Jews prior to Israeli statehood. Um Khalil, a Palestinian woman from a wealthy family from Anabta, by her account remembers, "the Muslim families would go to their Jewish neighbors and light the candles. The Jews would come and do things for us. We never thought that they were enemies. We were friends together" (Lynd et al., 27). Another Palestinian, Salah Ta'amari from Bethlehem who grew up during the 1948 war, remarks, "Jews were a part of this indistinguishable group of people. My grandfather's generation never spoke ill of Jews; they almost spoke of a good relationship" (68).

The question is: what changed for the relationship between Jews and Muslims in Israel-Palestine to become so strained? There was evidently a catalyst for the extreme violence beginning in Mandate Palestine to upset the Jewish, Muslim, and Christian coexistence. By studying two major instances of violence in which Jews were targeted during the Mandate period, the Nabi Musa riots and the Wailing Wall riots, this paper argues that Palestinian nationalism was primarily motivated by the political implications of Zionism. Antisemitism is certainly present in the rhetoric and generalizations that all Jews were necessarily Zionists, but that conflation resulted from political tensions between two nationalist ideologies. There was no extreme pre-existing antisemitism in the Muslim Arab population; in fact before World War I, Ottoman society

had been progressing toward greater social equality for the Jewish and Christian minorities. Instead, any hostility towards Jews that developed during the Mandate period arose from fear of what Zionism would mean for the Palestinian state and Arab political and religious rights.

Defining Antisemitism

Antisemitism is frequently used as a rhetorical tool in Palestinian-Israeli discourse to explain tragic events and bring attention to the moral stakes of the debate. Many believe that anti-Zionism, as in criticizing Israel's actions or its legitimacy (not necessarily calling for destruction of Israel today), is akin to antisemitism, and that to dislike Israel as a state is the same as hating Jews. For example, New York Times columnist Roger Cohen reports that Jews in Europe "speak of alarm as pro-Palestinian sentiment surges," meaning that European Jews expect increased antisemitism as anti-Zionism gains popularity (Cohen, 2023). There is widespread public perception that anti-Zionism is anti-Jewish, which regrettably dismisses pro-Palestinian activism as hateful. Therefore, it is essential to determine which of the many definitions of antisemitism is conducive to productive political discussions about Israel, Zionism, and Palestinian nationalism.

There have been several attempts to define antisemitism by associating it with racism and xenophobia to better contextualize and explain it as a uniquely religious and cultural othering. The term "antisemitism" only became "socially significant" after World War II to explain and describe the prejudice and hatreds that motivated the Holocaust (Langmuir, 351). Attempts to describe antisemitism fall short when the term is associated with "racism" or "ethnic prejudice," which imply that Jewish people constitute a race or ethnicity, a false idea that ignores the racial diversity of Jews and racial discrimination within the Jewish community (314). Therefore, the othering of Jewish people is more closely related to xenophobia, or fear of an outsider (329). The comparison to xenophobia describes the historic discrimination felt by Jews in Europe well, because Jews as a group were unable to assimilate into European society and were treated as second class citizens who were not a part of the national identity. Any definition of antisemitism should consider the assumption about how Jews are characterized within the definition.

The International Holocaust Remembrance Alliance (IHRA) definition, which is widely accepted as

the best definition of antisemitism, is weak because it is too vague and favors the association between anti-Zionism and antisemitism. The IHRA's definition of antisemitism is "a certain perception of Jews, which may be expressed as hatred toward Jews. Rhetorical and physical manifestations of antisemitism are directed toward Jewish or non-Jewish individuals and/or their property, toward Jewish community institutions and religious facilities." Jan Deckers and Jonathan Coulter point out that the IHRA's definition does not address the distinction between, as the IHRA puts it, "hatred toward Jews" versus "hatred for Jews," or hatred for Jews for being Jewish (734). For example, one cannot claim that condemning Prime Minister Netanyahu for his actions as a political leader is antisemitic simply because he happens to be Jewish. A more comprehensive definition would clarify that hatred toward Jews is based on stereotypes and prejudice attached to the religious and cultural aspects of the Jewish faith and community.

The definition of antisemitism that this paper will refer to is that of The Jerusalem Declaration on Antisemitism (JDA): "Antisemitism is discrimination, prejudice, hostility or violence against Jews as Jews or Jewish institutions as Jewish." The JDA also provides a list of examples of antisemitism, which are useful as a check on certain rhetoric and actions. The only guideline by the JDA that does not apply to this historical investigation is section B, point 10: "Denying the right of Jews in the State of Israel to exist and flourish, collectively and individually, as Jews, in accordance with the principle of equality." Because this paper examines the Mandate period, before Israel declared its statehood, antisemitism and anti-Zionism must be treated as separate. Antisemitism is hatred of a religious and cultural identity, and anti-Zionism is a rejection of a nationalist ideology that happens to be tied to Judaism and the Jewish community.

The observable implications of antisemitism include actions that socially and politically alienate and villainize Jews. For example, since the Middle Ages in Europe, Jews were persecuted, pushed out of European society, and consistently treated as second-class citizens. Zionism exists because of the heinous oppression and discrimination that Jews faced in Europe, which required the creation of a safe haven for the Jewish people, who had little hope for equality in Europe. In recent European history, Jews have been removed from leadership, like in the Dreyfus Affair; blamed for national failures, like after World War I; and been victims of ethnic cleansing, such as

the tragic genocide committed during the Holocaust. Antisemitism in the Middle East would look much the same, with a primarily Muslim society specifically preventing Jews from having economic, political, social, and religious rights in the aforementioned ways. Similarly, consistent accusatory, conspiratorial rhetoric and targeted violence against Jews as followers of Judaism constitute observable antisemitism.

Muslims, Christians, and Jews during the Ottoman Empire

The relationship between Muslims and Jews in the Ottoman Empire looked very different from the relationship between European Christians and Jews. In the nineteenth century Ottoman Empire, the Muslim Arab majority ruled and Jewish and Christian Arabs were small minorities, with only about 9.5 percent of the population being Christian and 3.2 percent Jewish (Dowty, 7). The Ottoman Empire referred to Jews and Christians as *dhimmi*s (“people of the pact”) who, under the Pact of Umar, were permitted to govern themselves so long as they respected the occasional authority of the local Muslim sultans (Sharkey, 39). Christians and Jews did not enjoy all the same social and political rights as Muslims, but nor were they violently persecuted for their religion like they were in Europe, and nineteenth-century reforms were beginning to dissolve some of the hierarchies that favored Muslims. Christians and Jews were not restricted economically and permitted to accrue wealth; they served in some mixed courts, maintained autonomous communities, and practiced their religion and culture freely (162–163). While some scholars claim that there is a tradition of anti-Jewish hatred in the religion of Islam, there is no strong evidence to suggest that was the case in the Ottoman period (Herf, 5). In general, Jews and Christians were recognized and respected as “people of the book” because they shared the belief in the one God (Sharkey, 39). In general, any religious discrimination was against both Christians and Jews as the minority religious groups in the Ottoman Empire.

When Jews were threatened for their religious identities at the time, it was more often due to European Christian provocation. One notable incident was the Damascus affair in 1840 where Catholic missionaries at the French consulate in the Ottoman Empire accused Jews of having killed a Capuchin priest and spread blood libel myths targeting the local Jewish community (Sharkey, 156). The authorities, under direction from the French, searched the Jewish quarter and tortured innocent Jews. Cruel lies about Jewish communities,

like those spread by the European missionaries, were novel and shocking to Muslims (156). Indeed, Jews were not nearly subjugated in the Ottoman Empire to the extent to which Jews were subjugated in Europe, and events like the Damascus affair were uncommon. During the late nineteenth century, Muslims, Middle Eastern Jews, and Jewish European immigrants, for the most part, had a nonviolent relationship that was improving. As for non-Arab Jews, although they did not fully assimilate into Ottoman Palestine, they did not feel threatened for their religious or national origins (Dowty, 120). From the end of the Ottoman Empire to the declaration of the state of Israel, the relationship between Muslims and Jews changed dramatically.

Violence and Nationalism

The Nabi Musa riots took place during the Nabi Musa festival in April of 1920 and was one of the first violent conflicts between Jewish communities and Muslim Arab nationals in Palestine. The festival was a religious pilgrimage to the Nabi Musa Tomb, the tomb of Moses, located in the east of Jerusalem. The festival had changed from previous years to include Jaffa Gate, one of the entrances to the Old City. Jaffa Gate was a symbol of modernity and the Ottoman Empire, due to the large Ottoman clock tower above it and the Turkish customs house below it (Mazza, 64). The choice to lead the procession through Jaffa Gate gave the festival a distinct political character. There, several elite Palestinian leaders gave inflammatory speeches attacking Jews and Zionism, catalysing the violence. There are several accounts of who began the violence, some pointing to Zionists provoking the crowd, others blaming it on Arab instigators, revealing the conflicting cultural memory of the event. In the end, rioters looted Jewish shops, beat spectators, and shot members of the procession, and in addition to the subsequent violent retaliation, the riots left five Jews and four Muslim Arabs dead (66).

The rhetoric leading up to the outbreak of violence ranged from blatant antisemitic remarks to somewhat more legitimate calls for resistance. Blatant antisemitism lacks a connection to the political and serves to insult, humiliate, hurt, and dehumanize. Then-mayor of Jerusalem, Musa Kazim al-Husayni, aggressively proclaimed, “Palestine is our land, Jews are our dogs,” while the famed journalist and historian, Aref al-Aref, announced, “if we don’t use force against the Jews, we will never be rid of them” (66). Musa Kazim al-Husayni’s statement is certainly antisemitic, characterizing Jews as a group as submissive,

subhuman, and lacking basic dignity. On the other hand, Aref al-Aref's statement is clearly more political and nationalistic in his reference to the flood of Jewish immigrants into Palestine, suggesting that antisemitic beliefs in Palestinian nationalist movements stemmed from fear of Zionism.

Determining the role of antisemitism in the Nabi Musa riots means determining what the violence was motivated by, keeping in mind the definition of antisemitism: "discrimination, prejudice, hostility or violence against Jews as Jews" (JDA). By studying several instances of mass violence, including the Holocaust, Jacques Semelin determines that inflammatory discourse that leads to violence occurs when "myths and realities are intertwined" (Semelin, 22). The myth that some Palestinian leaders were projecting was the generalization that all Jews are Zionists attempting to take over Palestine, but there was still the apparent reality that much of the European Jewish immigration into Mandate Palestine was to create a Jewish majority for the Jewish state. On the other hand, Zionists who took part in the riots also held the myth that Palestinians were a savage people, but there was still the reality that many Muslims were prepared to use violence against Jewish people to stop the immigration. It is difficult to determine whether individual Arabs participating in the violence acted on their perception of Jews in general or their judgments of Zionism, but what is certain is that the changing political situation in Palestine greatly contributed to the intensity of conflict. The Nabi Musa riots should not be interpreted uniquely as antisemitic outburst given that there were substantial political changes occurring when the violence broke out.

Violence against Jews in Mandate Palestine was primarily a manifestation of an Arab political struggle against Zionism. During Ottoman rule in Jerusalem, protests, riots, massacres, and violent demonstrations were mild, common, and not along religious lines (Mazza, 62). In fact, it was seen as a legitimate way of bringing attention to a political struggle, or as Roberto Mazza describes it: "social practice that leads to social change" (62). Political violence early on in the Israeli-Palestinian conflict was largely uncoordinated and there were no militant groups organizing riots and attacks. Palestinian rioters were responding to the increased European Jewish immigration into Palestine that resulted in Arabs selling their land, therefore limiting the geographical and demographic dominance of the Muslim Arab population. Much of the violence was specifically against European Jewish land buyers because they represented a direct example

of apparent Zionist goals in Palestine (McDowall, 11). The concentration of violence around land purchasing and changing neighborhoods signals that the violence likely originated from political concerns and fears of displacement. Violence was not specifically directed toward Jews as Jews at this point, but more specifically Zionist immigrants, as illustrated by a 1919 newspaper article "Beware of Zionist Danger" noting the "Zionist desire to settle in our country and expel us from it" (12). The idea was reasonable given that in private, Zionist leaders had agreed that a demographic Jewish majority was necessary for the Jewish state, but they must have understood that advertising the plan to transfer Muslim Arabs out of the country would trigger a strong reaction (Morris, 41). Regardless, Arabs did indeed assume that under the Zionist state, they would be evicted (Palin et al., 15). The European Zionist goal of creating a country in Palestine while undermining the people already there was terrifying to Arabs.

The notion that the violence was primarily motivated by nationalism is supported by the British authorities at the time who commissioned a report to investigate the source of the violence. Despite being biased toward Zionism, given that Great Britain had declared Palestine the new home of the Jewish people in the Balfour Declaration in 1917, the British report still stated that Palestinian grievances and their violent reaction were valid. Major General Sir Philip Palin proceeded over the Commission and interviewed 152 witnesses in eight languages, but the Commission was never published due to the anticipated Zionist pushback over the characterization of the riots (Britain Palestine Project). The Commission began by outlining the racial, ethnic, and religious division within Jerusalem in an attempt to outline the shift away from peaceful relationships between Muslim, Christian, and Jewish communities. British officials believed Muslims and Christians saw the Jewish population as "humble" and "inoffensive," and they reported that there was no regular major violence directed toward Jewish communities (5). Subsequent points summarized how the Palestinians were deeply disappointed that the British did not give them an independent state after observing the European international emphasis on self-determination, and the content of the Balfour Declaration denying Palestinians political rights. The Commission describes Muslims and Christians as feeling "dumbfounded" and "bitter" that "they were to be handed over to an oppression which they hated far more than the Turks and were aghast at the thought of this domination" (10). The Palin Commission connected the riots to the unfulfilled promise of statehood.

The Palin Commission emphasized the Palestinian Arabs' fear of European Jewish immigrants. Palestinians perceived Jewish immigrants as a threat, due to their wealth and ability to buy Palestinian land, and because they had the backing of an imperial power. The Commission conceded that these fears were not entirely misplaced, given that these were essentially the goals of Zionism and the content of the Balfour Declaration. The Commission quoted the Grand Mufti Kamil al-Husayni, the religious and political leader of Arabs in Jerusalem: "I too believe the Jews could greatly help our country, but what terrifies us are the extremists and the uncontrolled immigration" (15). The Grand Mufti judges the Jewish people not on their faith or culture, but on the political consequences of their mass migration. In addition, the Commission reported on Zionist media that had been directly outlining the plan "to remove the Arabs from the country by force" (21). Naturally, Arabs reacted in a panic having gone from thinking they would have their state to fearing they would be taken from their homes. The Palin Commission concluded the essential cause of the riots was a mix of a political reality, fear, and generalization, not hatred toward Jews as followers of Judaism, but as supporters of Zionism.

The Nabi Musa riots were an Arab reaction to Jewish immigration and fear of Zionism that would undermine the possibility of the widely desired Palestinians state. The character of the Palestinian nationalist movement at this time had not taken on the Islamist tone assumed to be present in all Palestinian nationalist movements. In fact, after World War I, there was some desire for a secular democratic state that would protect the civil and political rights of all members of Palestinian society. A 1919 Memorandum of the General Syrian Congress to the King-Crane Commission called for a "democratic civil constitutional monarchy on board decentralized principles safeguarding the rights of minorities and opposing the Zionist settlement of Palestine" (McDowall, 15). Palestinian nationalism was not primarily driven by hatred of Jews or the Jewish faith; instead there was wide-spread existential fear of Arab disenfranchisement by European immigrants. Fear of Zionism did at times manifest in some antisemitic rhetoric and attacks targeting Jews indiscriminately because of the assumption that most Jews were proponents of Zionism. Yet, the political purpose of the Nabi Musa riots and the political goals of Palestinian nationalism were primarily to demonstrate against the creation of the Jewish state outlined in the Balfour Declaration that would deny the political rights of thousands of Arab Palestinians. In the early 1920s,

Palestinian nationalism was secular and political, and distinctly different from the militant Islam that we see today.

Palestinian Nationalism and Religion

The Nabi Musa riots demonstrated how political fear of mass migration generated violence against Jewish people, while the Wailing Wall riots nine years later showed how religious sites became proxies for nationalist competition. The Wailing Wall riots in August 1929 saw the use of religious dispute to promote nationalist ideologies by Muslim Arab Leaders, particularly the Grand Mufti of Jerusalem. The Wailing Wall is the western border of the Temple Mount and Haram al-Sharif and it is the holiest religious site in Jerusalem for both Jews and Muslims. The Western Wall in Judaism is the remaining section of the original Temple Mount and became a symbol for the suffering of Jews in the modern world (Mazza, 71). The Wailing Wall or "the place of wailing" in Islam is where the Prophet Mohammed tethered his magical stallion, al-Buraq, during his Night Journey to Jerusalem (72). The dispute over the Wall in 1929 grew tense when Zionists tried to purchase sections of the Wall in the Maghrebi quarter to create space for the growing number of Jewish worshipers at the Wall, drawing attention to the Zionist aims in the city (72). Zionists' attempts to claim the Wall upset the peaceful balance between Jewish and Muslim worshipers and represented an encroachment on the religious and cultural identities of Muslim Arabs.

The Wailing Wall riots originated from months of tension at the Wall. Following peaceful Jewish demonstrations in August of 1929, some 2,000 Arab Muslims marched to the Wailing Wall, and some marchers burned Torahs that were left there, a distinct sign of hatred and intolerance. Later in the month, Arabs were given a false message that the Mufti had instructed them to gather in defense of the Wall, and after several speeches, the crowd rushed out of the Haram and the violence began (46). Mazza describes these riots as a massacre, using the definition "the murder of the defenseless in a distinct time and place when the killers are not in danger" because the violence was mostly Arabs attacking Jews in Arab neighborhoods, and Jews attacking Arabs in Jewish neighborhoods (Mazza, 75). For example, Arab attacks took place in the Gurji quarter, now in East Jerusalem, and Jews targeted the Nabi 'Ukkasha Mosque in the Jewish section of Central Jerusalem (75). Attacks took place for several days all throughout the city. Religious disputes over control of holy sites were common in

Jerusalem, but the Wailing Wall riots were especially intense and bloody due to its connection to conflicting nationalist struggles (Mattar, 34). In the end, 133 Jews and 116 Muslim Arabs died.

To determine the extent of antisemitism in the Wailing Wall riots, we must investigate the new Grand Mufti of Jerusalem Hajj Amin al-Husayni's role as the head of the Palestinian nationalist movement in the city. A common narrative is that Amin incited the violence and encouraged religious fanatics to attack Jews. Although he did not encourage violence, Amin used the religious dispute to bring attention to the nationalist struggle. Amin had been exiled by British authorities, pardoned, and eventually appointed Mufti by British high commissioner Herbert Samuel, a member of the Jewish Liberal Party and a committed Zionist, after winning the election (Mattar, 20, 27). The position of Mufti was religious as well as political, but Amin's main goal, and the reason why he was so popular, was supporting Palestinian nationalism morally and monetarily (30). As the Mufti of Jerusalem and the president of the Supreme Muslim Council, he was obliged to defend the Muslim claims over the Wall (37). Unlike previous religious disputes, the Wall dispute was distinctly nationalist with Zionists calling "to pour Jews into Palestine" to reclaim the homeland and the Wall (38). Amin convened the General Muslim Council to address the Zionist claim over the Wailing Wall by creating the Society for the Defense of al-Masjid al-Aqsa and the Muslim Holy Places which created propaganda to publicize the conflict and draw attention to the effects of Jewish immigration (Porath, 272). One newspaper under Amin's direction proclaimed, "The Muslims of Palestine are determined to sacrifice body and soul in order to safeguard their religious rights. It is enough that their national rights have been stolen from them" (266). On the day the violence broke out, Amin urged that day's preacher to deliver a calm sermon, and he encouraged members of the crowd to enter the Mosque instead of demonstrating outside (Mattar, 47). Amin was not attempting to incite violence for the sake of violence, although his use of religious imagery inflamed the inter-religious tension and resulted in bloodshed, his goal was primarily to bring attention to the negative effects of Zionism on Arab life and mobilize resistance against Jewish immigration.

Religion was evidently critical for the Mufti's constituents and an important component of Arab identity, which Amin understood. For example, he inflated the budget costs of restoring a mosque to cover up money being used for demonstrations and political propaganda (Porath, 203). Religious rights were one

of the rights listed for Arabs in Palestine in the Balfour Declaration, meaning Amin, in his cooperation with the British, could reasonably advocate for control over religious sites and rights for Muslims. He recognized the sensitivity of religion for Arabs present in the political conflict between Zionists and Palestinians, therefore restoration and protection of mosques and religious sites became the new fighting ground for Palestinian nationalist aims. Yehoshua Porath describes Amin's strategy during the conflict as "instead of abstract nationalist slogans about self-determination, majority rights etc., they now had a concrete symbol which was clearly understood by the Muslim masses" (272).

Narratives that suggest that religion is the driving factor in this conflict wrongfully assume cultural differences to be as divisive as political ones. In a case study on the Chewa and Tumbuka communities in Malawi and Zambia, Daniel N. Posner investigates why there is far more division between the Chewas and Tumbukas in Malawi than in Zambia. Posner concludes that the political context in Malawi creates a bigger cleavage given that both groups are large coalitions who are "politically useful in the national competition for state resources," while in Zambia, the communities are too small for political use (543). In Palestine in 1929, national leaders mobilized the religious identities for the purpose of resisting changing demographics and burgeoning calls for Jewish statehood in Palestine. The conflict developing between Muslim Arabs and Jews in Palestine similarly included two distinct groups who had coexisted previously, but the introduction of a salient political problem, in this case mass migration, resulted in greater cleavage between the two religious communities.

The Shaw Commission, another British Commission organized to investigate the source of the violence, concluded that though the Mufti did not incite the massacres, he contributed to the tension by emphasizing the loss of Muslims' religious status at the Wall. The Shaw Commission is a reliable source because it provides a relatively balanced report of the events despite being carried out by the British authorities who were biased toward the political success of Zionism in Palestine at the time. The Commission describes the Wall dispute as being both a religious and political confrontation, providing evidence of possessiveness over the holy sites and fear of Zionism contributing. Amin began what the Commission refers to as the "Burak Campaign," wherein Amin and other Arab leadership advocated for Muslims rights over the Wailing Wall. The Shaw Commission described the purpose of the Burak Campaign as "to annoy the Jews,

and also to mobilize Arab opinion on the issue of the Wailing Wall” (Shaw et al., 74). The use of the mild and dismissive term “annoying” implies that the British did not believe the Burak Campaign was intended to incite mass violence and armed conflict against Jewish people. Up until the Balfour Declaration, Muslims had had priority over the religious sites in Jerusalem, and experiencing challenges to their religious sovereignty as well as challenges to their national sovereignty made the situation volatile. The Shaw Commission draws attention to the fact that, partly because of Amin, Zionism was entirely understood to be a threat to Arab rule:

No one who has been about the country as we have been and who has listened to the applause which greeted many passages in the addresses read to us by village heads and sheikhs could doubt that villagers and peasants alike are taking a very real and personal interest both in the effect of the policy of establishing a national home and in the question of the development of self-governing institutions in Palestine (Shaw et al., 129).

The country-wide resentment over ignored Arab desires for a state erupted during the riots. Because there is no reference in the Shaw Commission to religious or cultural differences, the strict political nature of the report suggests the violence against Jewish people was mostly due to their connection to Zionism and the fear that Arabs would lose their own claim to statehood. Religion is evidently the point of distinction between the two groups, so it played an important role in the conflict, but these differences were only exacerbated and problematized by nationalism.

Jacques Semelin categorizes mass violence as “destroying to subjugate,” “destroying to eradicate,” or “destroying to revolt” (Semelin, 327). Determining the political purpose of the mass violence during the Wailing Wall riots can determine the extent of antisemitism in the massacre. Destroying to subjugate and destroying to eradicate have a distinctly hateful association with antisemitism, especially given the legacy of the Holocaust: Nazi Germany’s hatred of Jews resulted in a policy to oppress and kill all Jews in Germany because they were Jewish, not for any legitimate political grievance. The violence in Palestinian nationalism, however, was not to subjugate or to exterminate. It is unlikely that Palestinian nationalists wanted all Jews in Palestine to be degraded, killed, or completely expelled, given that there were no prominent groups systematically organizing for these goals in Palestine. In fact, Arab states recognized the Jewish desire for a refuge in the Middle East by

putting forth a proposal for a Palestinian democratic state in a UN Subcommittee proposal in 1946 and 1947 to address European Jewish immigration while retaining Arab statehood. The proposal included a democratic constitution with guaranteed sanctity of the holy places, freedom of religion, Hebrew as the official second language in places where Jews are in the majority, representation in government based on the populations of distinct religious communities, and a pledge that “the guarantee contained in the constitution concerning the rights and safeguards of the minority shall not be subject to amendment or modification without the consent of the minority concerned” (Khalidi, 688–689). The proposal was never realized because the independent Arab state in Palestine after World War II was never established.

The violence committed by a segment Palestinian nationalist movement during these riots should be classified as destroying to revolt. Semelin describes destroying to revolt as “provoking a violent insurrection against a despised system” and a “self-revolt in that it hoped that the massacre would trigger an emancipating dynamic of the ‘masses’” (Semelin, 348). The Wailing Wall riots are distinctly different from other instances of destroying to revolt given that there were no terrorist or insurgent organizations conducting the violence; instead, the riots were a manifestation of tensions between Zionism and Palestinian nationalism after weeks of demonstrations where both parties claimed possession over the Wall. As the leader of Palestinian nationalism during the Mandate period, Amin sought to energize the Palestinian nationalist struggle by bringing attention to Zionist actions he saw as threatening Muslim Arab way of life, like their ability to worship at the Wailing Wall. To Palestinian nationals engaged in the violence, killing Jewish people was a disproportionate and extreme response to the despised system that the British set up in Mandate Palestine that prioritized Jewish statehood, Jewish immigration, and Jewish religious rights. Jews were not primarily targeted for their religion and culture, but they were attacked for being associated with Zionism and for challenging Muslim political dominance. Had it been Christians creating a state in Palestine and attempting to take possession of the Holy sites, the response may have been the same.

Antisemitism as a European Import

During the 1930s, as tensions between Muslims and Jews in Palestine grew, antisemitic Nazi propaganda reached the Arab world. In 1933, Amin contacted the head of the German Consulate in

Jerusalem welcoming the new regime and explaining his desires for weakening the economic power of Jews in Palestine and abroad (Herf, 16). The connection to Zionism is apparent given that Palestinian leadership was deeply concerned with the capability of Zionist immigrants to buy Palestinian land and were willing to discredit, exclude, and oppress European Jews to stop it. Amin was equally looking for an international ally to support the establishment of an independent Palestinian state. The relationship between Amin and the Nazi regime grew with Amin meeting with Hitler in the hopes of securing a relationship with a European power to challenge British and Zionist presence in Palestine (Nicosia, 85). The Nazis disguised their disdain for Arabs as non-Aryans and concealed that they did not intend to challenge British occupation in the region (Nicosia, 85). With the help of Amin, the Nazis launched a propaganda campaign spreading classically European antisemitic tropes to Arabs. For example, in a speech broadcasted from Berlin, Amin accused the world Jewish population of conspiring with the Allies and directing them to take over Palestine (Herf, 215). Part of the Nazi strategy was also to appeal to Arabs via religion and encourage jihad against Jews (Herf, 129). New lies were being fed to Muslims regarding Jews that, rather than relying on pre-existing antisemitic views, relied on Arab distrust of Zionism and the assumption that Germany would emancipate them from British and Zionist rule.

In the Arab world, antisemitism, as in hatred of Jews for being Jewish, grew as Arab leaders embraced Nazi propaganda in an attempt to undermine Zionism in Palestine in the 1930s (Herf, 5). This period marked a turning point for Jewish-Muslim relations. Distinctly European antisemitism, characterized by conspiratorial rhetoric about the world Jewish population, was everywhere. The Arab political conflict with Zionism became colored with religious stereotypes and prejudices. Antisemitic propaganda was effective in the region as Jewish immigration only increased and regional tensions grew. Nazi contributions toward antisemitism and jihadist ideology in the Middle East was substantial in expanding antisemitic rhetoric in the conflict.

Conclusion

The new hostile relationship between Palestinian Muslims and Jews solidified during what Palestinians refer to as “the Nakba,” or the catastrophe, during the Arab-Israeli 1948 war where half of the Arab population was either expelled or fled. Israel declared itself a state and Palestinian nationalism suffered a military, political,

and diplomatic defeat. With Israel’s declaration of statehood and the realization of Zionism, the future of Palestinian statehood was bleak. One hundred years of war and failed peace deals continue to contribute to the tension between Muslims and Jews and the discrimination, prejudice, and oppression prevalent on both sides. Denial of political rights and less and less hope for a Palestinian state draw more and more Palestinians to support radicals like Hamas, while Palestinian nationalism continues to be dismissed because of its association with antisemitism and terrorism. Following attacks against Israeli soccer fans in Amsterdam, former Prime Minister of Israel Ehud Olmert shared his thoughts with a New York Times columnist.

What happened in Amsterdam is primarily a reflection of hatred by many Muslims against the State of Israel and its citizens, because of what is transpiring in our region. It is not a continuation of the historic antisemitism that swept Europe in past centuries, the sources of which are Christian religious fanaticism and a lack of tolerance for the Jewish people in general. [...] The events in Amsterdam drew on deep roots in the past of the Jewish people. But they also drew on an unending stream of social media images of the devastation of Gaza without any Israeli plan offering a better way for Jews and Palestinians to live side-by-side. To focus entirely on the first and totally ignore the second is about the most dangerous thing Jews everywhere could do today (Friedman, 2024).

Olmert’s insight points out the way we oversimplify violence in this conflict and how delegitimizing Palestinian nationalism and ignoring the political causes of the conflict threatens peace and is dangerous for Jews. By investigating the limited extent to which antisemitism was present in early Palestinian nationalism, this paper hopes to challenge the way we consider religious difference and its connection to violence in the history of the movement.

In the Nabi Musa riots and the Wailing Wall riots, violence was an expression of a desperate and existential opposition to Zionism. Having been promised a state by the British, Palestinian nationals reacted strongly to their impending disenfranchisement. Antisemitic rhetoric was a result of hatred of Zionism, which Palestinians observed with the influx of European Jewish immigrants. Understanding these violent incidents is difficult because of the ambiguity of some of the evidence and the challenge of discerning motivations for individual rioters. However, given that Muslims and Jews had a peaceful relationship during the Ottoman period, it was likely not a latent widespread

antisemitism that prompted the riots, but more an extreme demonstration of political disagreement. The Nabi Musa riots marked a moment where a cultural and religious festival was transformed into a political demonstration, while the Wailing Wall riots illustrate how Arab religious sensitivity and fear of how Zionism would affect the religious sovereignty of Muslims in Jerusalem erupted into a massacre. Arab leaders recognized how Zionism and Jewish immigration would forever change Arab life in Palestine, so they embraced antisemitic Nazi propaganda in the 1930s in the hopes of using an alliance with Germany to stop Zionism.

Palestinian nationalism began as a movement focused on the creation of a Palestinian state to protect the political and religious rights of Palestinian Arabs. If a similar nationalist movement had been attempted by Christians or Europeans, Muslims Arabs would likely have had the same reaction. Historical analysis suggests that opposition to Zionist ideology at the time was not based in old religious hatred. Today, there is certainly antisemitism in the core beliefs of radical Palestinian nationalist groups, but the current narrative is far too simplistic because it discounts the evolution of the conflict and assumes Middle Eastern antisemitism has always been as rampant and historic as European antisemitism. Antisemitism in the Middle East does not have to be a fact of life. Considering antisemitism as a symptom of greater nationalist issues and not just the cause complicates how we envision a lasting peace that allows Muslims and Jews to prosper without fear of oppression and violence.

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